

happy as I was. Actually, they weren't thrilled with the sound or with the price tag, once I fessed up to how much the system cost me.

"How did you afford this?" my stepfather asked.

"I have a job, remember? Don't worry about it," I said, turning up the volume.

Nothing could dampen my enthusiasm. I felt I had purchased a source of joy, that I had made my first discerning, adult purchase, one that reflected my style, taste, and musical knowledge, which would net me the admiration of my friends and perhaps attention from girls for several counties around. My stepfather sighed, and he and my mother turned away, closing my bedroom door behind them.

The next week, I got laid off.

It's funny how something you love can become a source of simmering resentment within moments. I loved my stereo system that morning. A few days later, I entered my room at night, and instead of seeing a source of joy, I began to see a shiny stack of anxiety. Now what? The store wanted the rest of the money in a month, which had now shrunk to three weeks. If I didn't pay on time, I would begin to be charged 16 percent interest, compounded monthly. My \$3,500 bargain would become \$4,000, even \$5,000, in no time.

After experiencing a few days of awful panic, I did what a lot of teenagers do. I approached my parents to ask them to bail me out. I hadn't told them about the payment plan, only what I'd spent. The idea that I had something in my possession that wasn't fully paid for was anathema to my folks, especially my mother.

I explained my choices with great humility. Then I told them I had lost my job and that I needed to pay off the balance on the stereo or face crippling interest charges.

"Kevin, have you lost all good sense?" my mother said. "I can't believe that any son of mine would do something so foolish with his money. George, can you believe this?!" My parents looked at each other.

"Please," I said. "I need you to pay for the rest of the stereo."

Then, without exchanging so much as a word, my parents gave me a firm answer: "No."